Secretary Gates, interested parties, by which I mean Western governments, will often use the redaction issue – or the bogus issue of 'blood on hands' – to justify their calls for the documents to remain secret altogether. Against the grain of modern developments, they are essentially demanding censorship of these documents for political reasons. And my unwillingness to serve in that propaganda war allowed them to dub me as someone who was against redactions. In actual fact, we had been burning the midnight oil on redactions from early on. We didn't prove as squeamish as the governments, naturally, or indeed as squeamish as the *Guardian* or the *New York Times*, but we were judicious, I believe, and to date no one has come to harm as a result of what we published.

Although my view of all this had not changed, I could see ahead of the Iraq release that the myth of WikiLeaks' recklessness was threatening to damage our organisation and our future work. If you are to achieve anything significant in the world, you sometimes have to acknowledge expediencies, and I therefore decided to redact the Iraq diaries much more thoroughly than anything previously. Without the resources to do these redactions manually – especially since our media partners refused to help because they were scared of taking on the responsibility – we wrote a program to remove all names and all other identifying information automatically from the documents. I know that unthinking minds will condemn me for saying this, but I actually believe that our redactions of the Iraq material were too extensive. After the diaries revealed the collusion of American troops in the torture of hundreds of Iraqi prisoners by local forces, the Danish Ministry of Defence started an investigation into the behaviour of their own troops. At first they approached the Pentagon, asking for an unredacted copy of those sections of the diaries that referred to Danish soldiers. The Pentagon flatly refused, so instead the Danes asked us for the material, which we provided. Though some people may refuse to see this, open government is only worthy of the name when it is a real, lived value, not an empty branding exercise, and my attitude to redaction is coloured by this fact.

We had to prepare the Iraq diaries to some extent in an atmosphere of hysteria after the fallout from the earlier leak. The newspaper partners were working at a low energy level, as I said, and they had been slightly rocked by the scale of the response to the previous work. I've seen this before with media organisations: they want big stories, but they can't handle the heat